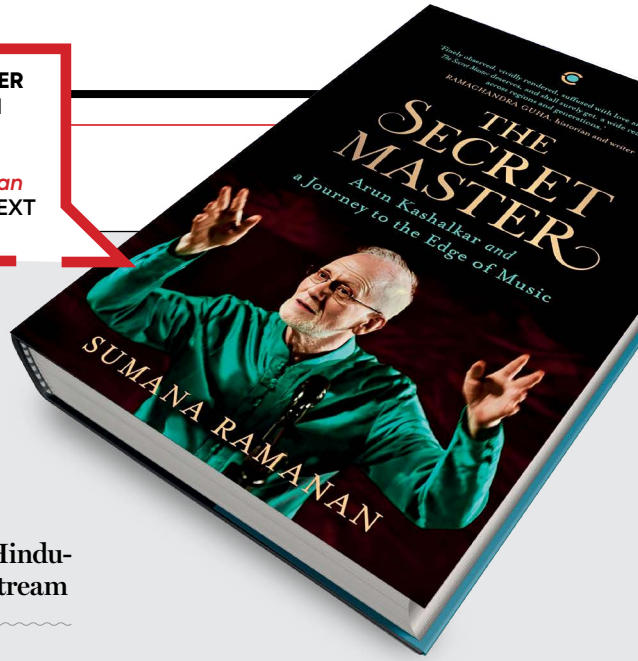
THE SECRET MASTER
Arun Kashalkar and a Journey to the Edge of Music
By Sumana Ramanan
WESTLAND/ CONTEXT
₹899; 466 pages



BOOKS ▼

Beyond the SPOTLIGHT

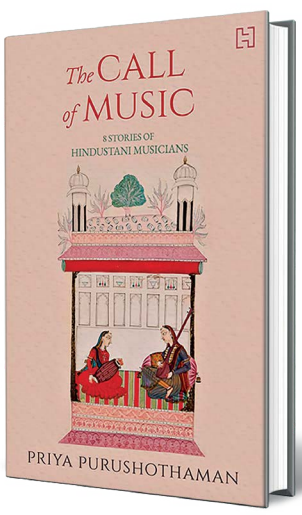
SUMANA RAMANAN's *The Secret Master* is a fine study of Hindustani vocalist Arun Kashalkar, revered outside of the mainstream

Sumana Ramanan's *The Secret Master: Arun Kashalkar and a Journey to the Edge of Music* offers a rare and intimate portrait of Hindustani vocalist Arun Kashalkar, a musician revered by connoisseurs yet less visible within the mainstream. Blending biography, cultural commentary and personal narrative, Ramanan explores why an artist of remarkable depth has remained largely outside wider public visibility.

The book begins with her moment of revelation: hearing Kashalkar at a private gathering, an encounter that sparks a meticulous and deeply engaged quest to understand his life, his music and the ecosystem that shaped both. Through interviews, archival material and her own experience as his student, Ramanan constructs a portrait that extends beyond the individual to illuminate the wider world of *khayal*.

THE AUTHOR DETAILS THE ROLE OF INSTITUTIONAL PATRONAGE AND STAR-LED FESTIVALS IN POPULARITY, INDEPENDENT OF A MUSICIAN'S ACCLAIM

Kashalkar emerges as a musician of exceptional intellect and versatility. Rooted primarily in the Agra *gharana* with formative grounding in Gwalior and some influence from Jaipur, he is also a composer under the pen name Rasdaas and a teacher whose rigour is matched by a reflective, understated presence. Ramanan captures his artistry with an admirable balance of detail and clarity.



THE CALL OF MUSIC:
8 Stories of Hindustani Musicians
By Priya Purushothaman
HACHETTE
Rs 699; 304 pages

BOOKS ▼

Singing in the Shadows

THE POIGNANT PROFILES IN *THE CALL OF MUSIC* SHOW THAT A LIFE OF MUSIC IS FRAUGHT WITH CHALLENGES

Vocalist-author Priya Purushothaman's unusual account of musicians is united by their modest and often marginalised positions within the world of performance.

There is the fraught story of vocalist Sudhindra Bhaumik, trained at IIT and IIM, whose quest for music was a restless oscillation between conventional jobs and his artistic muse. Rumi Harish is a skilled vocalist who had to confront gender conventions in music while transitioning to becoming a man. Shubha Joshi struggled with her broad voice until she discovered that genres like thumri allowed for alternative conventions of singing. Shubhada Paradkar, as a young mother and homemaker, used every extra hour she could find to continue her music training.

Suhail Yusuf Khan's grandfather was a celebrated sarangi maestro, but Suhail found the burden of musical conventions oppressive—particularly because his family belonged to a caste of traditional performers. Alam Khan, son of the legendary maestro Ali Akbar Khan, also found that the West–East divide was no